NCCP 00213 · VERSION 7

Your treatment, explained

Advanced / metastatic colorectal cancer · NCCP 00213 v7 · Document revised 4 November 2026

Your personal plan: this is the standard regimen schedule. Your team confirms your prescribed doses, cycles, treatment changes and appointments in your written plan.

Irinotecan · every three weeks

21-day cycle

Source reconciled; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending

ACT ON SYMPTOMS, NOT THE CALENDAR

When to get help

Emergency: call 112 / 999

Severe breathing difficulty, collapse, seizure or severe chest pain: call emergency services. Do not wait for an online answer.

Contact your oncology service immediately

Temperature 37.5°C or higher, 36°C or lower, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell — even with a normal temperature. New breathing difficulty, chest pain, collapse, severe diarrhoea or inability to drink require prompt assessment.

Follow the urgent contact instructions from your treating hospital. If you cannot reach the team, seek urgent medical assessment. Outside clinic hours, use your instructed out-of-hours pathway or the emergency department.

This page does not diagnose symptoms or decide whether it is safe to stay at home. You do not need to know which medicine caused a symptom before calling.

Open your CUH contact / treatment card

Sources: nccp · hse

Choose a topic to read

YOUR COMPLETE REFERENCE

Read what you need, when you need it.

Start with the overview, explore the cycle, or go straight to a question. Urgent advice is always available.

- How each drug works
- Treatment, recovery and review
- Your 21-day timeline
- Baseline and cycle-specific checks
- Whole treatment, scans and checks
- Tablets, visits and practical planning
- Your treatment aim
- Before the first treatment
- Symptoms in context
- Living with treatment
- Visits and treatment sequence
- When treatment changes or ends
- Blood tests between infusion visits
- Supportive medicines
- Understanding the evidence
- Questions to ask

Sources

UNDERSTAND YOUR TREATMENT

How your medicines work

The aim is to control advanced bowel cancer and symptoms. The team reviews how well treatment is working and whether side effects remain acceptable; there is no single fixed number of cycles for everyone.

TOPOISOMERASE I CHEMOTHERAPY

Irinotecan

Campto



Interrupts DNA copying

The body converts irinotecan into SN-38. This traps an enzyme called topoisomerase I while DNA is being copied, causing damage that can stop cancer cells dividing. Normal bowel and blood-forming cells can also be affected.

Irinotecan becomes SN-38 → DNA-repair enzyme is trapped → Dividing cells are damaged

What to watch for

Tell the nurse immediately about cramps, sweating or diarrhoea during the infusion. Diarrhoea starting later needs the separate written treatment and contact plan.

Sources: nccp

The drawings are simplified explanations of drug action, not anatomical pictures or a prediction of response.

Explore your existing anatomy and side-effect map

THE BIGGER TREATMENT PLAN

Treatment, recovery and review

CLINIC → HOME → REVIEW

A 21-day reference cycle



Irinotecan on Day 1 every 21 days while beneficial and tolerable. There is no home chemotherapy pump. Blood counts are checked weekly, including between infusion visits.

A repeating reference cycle sits within a longer treatment plan. The oncology team chooses the number of cycles and confirms changes; no patient dates are required here.

Sources: nccp

BASELINE → TREATMENT → FOLLOW-UP

When checks happen

The columns show order, not equal periods. There is no fixed number of cycles for these plans. Agree who books each check, when results are reviewed and whom to contact if a check is missed.

Check	Before starting	Early treatment	Repeated treatment	Longer-term review	Pause / completion
Blood counts, kidney and liver	Baseline blood count, kidney and liver profile	Review results before treatment	Weekly blood count; kidney and liver tests before each cycle	Repeat sooner if symptoms or results need it	Follow any unresolved abnormal result
Bowel symptoms and hydration	Have a written diarrhoea plan and emergency contact	Tell the nurse about cramps, sweating or diarrhoea during infusion	Delayed diarrhoea can start after the first day; act using your written plan	Fever, reduced urine, severe pain or inability to drink needs urgent advice	Restart decisions require recovery and team review
Cancer response and treatment choices	Record baseline disease and agree review plan	Bring forward review if symptoms worsen	Scans and other tests follow your consultant's treatment plan	Discuss benefit, side effects and whether the goal has changed	Agree continuation, a break, another treatment or supportive care

The team arranges and reviews tests. This guide shows expected timing; it does not record completed appointments. NCCP 00213 v7 · official regimen

THE WHOLE TREATMENT JOURNEY

Irinotecan · every three weeks: treatment and checks

Advanced / metastatic colorectal cancer

Irinotecan on Day 1 every 21 days while beneficial and tolerable. There is no home chemotherapy pump. Blood counts are checked weekly, including between infusion visits.

Read from left to right. Columns show stages, not equal lengths of time. This is a general plan: no dates or personal information are needed. Your team confirms which steps apply and arranges appointments.

On a small screen, swipe the map sideways. The checks below give the same timing in words.

Treatment, tests and reviews across the course

Care / check	Before starting	Early treatment	Repeated treatment	Longer-term review	Pause / completion
Blood counts, kidney and liver NCCP 00213	Baseline blood count, kidney and liver profile	Review results before treatment	Weekly blood count; kidney and liver tests before each cycle	Repeat sooner if symptoms or results need it	Follow any unresolved abnormal result
Bowel symptoms and hydration NCCP 00213	Have a written diarrhoea plan and emergency contact	Tell the nurse about cramps, sweating or diarrhoea during infusion	Delayed diarrhoea can start after the first day; act using your written plan	Fever, reduced urine, severe pain or inability to drink needs urgent advice	Restart decisions require recovery and team review
Cancer response and treatment choices NCCP 00213	Record baseline disease and agree review plan	Bring forward review if symptoms worsen	Scans and other tests follow your consultant’s treatment plan	Discuss benefit, side effects and whether the goal has changed	Agree continuation, a break, another treatment or supportive care

What each check is for

1

A 21-day reference cycle

Clinic → home → review

The aim is to control advanced bowel cancer and symptoms. The team reviews how well treatment is working and whether side effects remain acceptable; there is no single fixed number of cycles for everyone.

Ask / act: Confirm the phase, prescription, tests and supportive medicines before starting.

Sources: NCCP 00213

At the next review, ask

- Which treatment phase am I in, and what happens next?
- Which test is expected next, who arranges it, and who explains the result?
- Who should I contact if an expected appointment has not arrived?

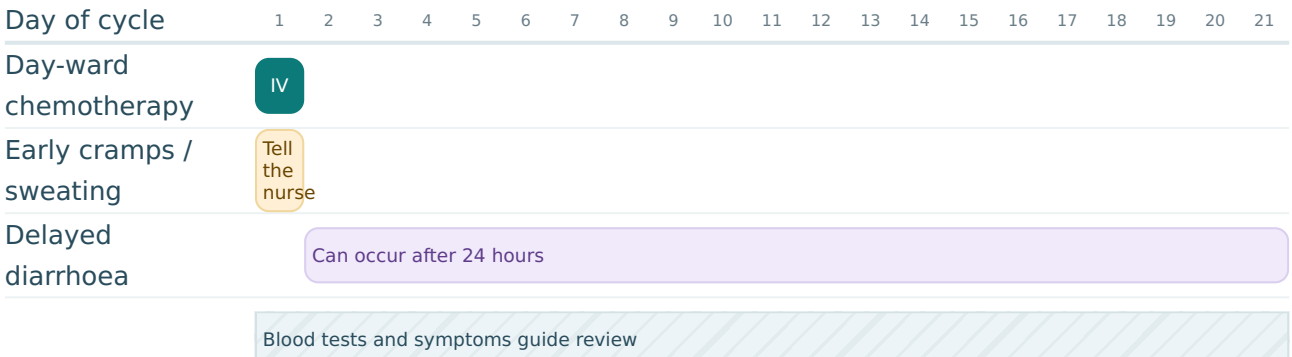
This map does not show whether a test has been ordered, booked or completed. Do not wait for a scheduled test if you develop new symptoms.

Sources checked 2026-11-04 · Source reconciled; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending · SACTCheck v0.84.33

Day 1 → Day 21: a general pattern

This is a visual orientation, not a prediction of your personal cycle. It shows when some effects often emerge and which effects are **not** tied to a particular day.

Irinotecan on Day 1 every 21 days while beneficial and tolerable. There is no home chemotherapy pump. Blood counts are checked weekly, including between infusion visits.



Blood counts / infection risk	
Energy and bowel symptoms	Variable timing

Your planned visits: Irinotecan is given on Day 1; no home fluorouracil pump. A repeating 21-day cycle. The number of cycles depends on benefit, side effects and your treatment plan.

Care continues: Continue the bowel-symptom plan, blood tests and follow-up arranged by your team; report delayed diarrhoea promptly. Ask which medicines to continue and when your next review is planned.

No guaranteed safe days: An infection, reaction or other urgent problem can occur at any time. The graph does not predict a personal low point.

> **Why these bands stay broad:** NCCP defines the treatment days. Symptom bands are broad educational guidance; reactions can occur on any day, and cumulative effects may continue between cycles. Band length does not show likelihood or severity, and the chart cannot tell you whether it is safe to receive treatment. NCCP 00213 v7 · official regimen ↗

> **There are no guaranteed “safe days”.** Fever, shivers or suddenly feeling unwell require immediate contact. Serious symptoms override any timeline or diary.

Read the whole cycle as text

Day 1: Treatment and checks

The team reviews blood tests, symptoms and your prescription before treatment. Know the contact number and the next planned visit.

Day 2–10: Care between visits

Follow the skin-care or bowel-symptom plan provided. There is no pump to remove. Call early for symptoms; do not wait for the next appointment.

Day 11–21: Recovery and the next review

The team uses symptoms, tests and your priorities to decide what happens next. Bring questions and a symptom record if useful; this is optional.

PRACTICAL TREATMENT GUIDE

Visits, access and care between treatments

Irinotecan on Day 1 every 21 days while beneficial and tolerable. There is no home chemotherapy pump. Blood counts are checked weekly, including between infusion visits.



STEP 1

Paper copies, wallet QR and contacts

The example telephone numbers on the wallet card are placeholders. Your team must replace them with working daytime and out-of-hours numbers before patient use. Keep the card with you; the QR opens the regimen information, not your confidential medical record.

Transport and daily life

Plan transport if antihistamines, symptoms or other medicines affect driving. Ask for practical, work, nutrition or emotional support.

If treatment changes

Ask which component has been held and which visits remain. A treatment delay does not automatically cancel blood tests, line care or symptom follow-up.

Open practical treatment guide · **Printable practical guide**

Sources: NCCP 00213 v7 · official regimen. Source reconciled; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending.

MAKE THE PLAN PRACTICAL

Support around the medicines

1 Before treatment

The team checks blood counts, kidney/liver function, symptoms, allergies and medicines. Weekly blood counts are part of this irinotecan plan.

2 Bowel symptoms and fluids

Irinotecan can cause early cramps/sweating during infusion and delayed diarrhoea after 24 hours. You need separate instructions for each. Follow your written rescue plan. Fever, blood, severe pain, reduced urine or inability to drink needs urgent advice.

3 Plan the visit

Allow for blood tests, review, pharmacy preparation, infusion and observation. A port is not automatically required; ask which access is suitable.

4 Comfort and daily life

Use prescribed anti-sickness medicines, pace activities and ask for nutritional, emotional or practical support.

5 The whole treatment plan

Ask how and when the team will assess benefit, which blood tests continue during a pause, and what happens after the final dose. Weekly blood counts remain part of the irinotecan plan between visits.

Sources: nccp · hse

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 01

Your treatment aim

The setting changes what benefit means.

Why this option?

Irinotecan alone is used for advanced bowel cancer after a fluorouracil-containing treatment has failed. Your team explains the aim, alternatives and how benefit will be reviewed.

Sources: nccp

A plan that can change

For this advanced-cancer treatment, discuss cancer control, symptom relief and how benefit will be reviewed. Ask about other options, treatment burdens and your priorities.

Sources: nccp

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 02

Before the first treatment

Checks reduce avoidable risk.

Blood tests and medicines

Review blood counts, kidney/liver tests, symptoms, allergies and all medicines and supplements.

Sources: nccp

Preparing access

Allow for blood tests, review, pharmacy preparation, infusion and observation. A port is not automatically required; ask which access is suitable.

Sources: nccp

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 03

Symptoms in context

Report what changed and how it affects you.

When to call

New breathing difficulty, chest pain, collapse, severe diarrhoea or inability to drink require prompt assessment.

Sources: nccp · hse

Bowel symptoms

Irinotecan can cause early cramps/sweating during infusion and delayed diarrhoea after 24 hours. You need separate instructions for each. Follow your written rescue plan. Fever, blood, severe pain, reduced urine or inability to drink needs urgent advice.

Sources: nccp

Skin or nerve changes

Use prescribed anti-sickness medicines, pace activities and ask for nutritional, emotional or practical support.

Sources: nccp

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 04

Living with treatment

Use the support available.

Food, activity and practical help

Use prescribed anti-sickness medicines, pace activities and ask for nutritional, emotional or practical support.

Sources: nccp · hse

Pregnancy and fertility

Discuss fertility preservation and reproductive plans before treatment. Ask for the contraception and breastfeeding instructions for every medicine; the whole regimen may require longer precautions than one medicine alone.

Sources: nccp

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 05

Visits and treatment sequence

Know which steps happen in the clinic and at home.

The exact delivery plan

Irinotecan is given on Day 1; no home fluorouracil pump. A repeating 21-day cycle. The number of cycles depends on benefit, side effects and your treatment plan.

Sources: nccp

Radiotherapy relationship

This NCCP regimen does not contain a routine radiotherapy course. If radiation is recommended separately, ask whether it is before, during or after these medicines.

Sources: nccp

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 06

When treatment changes or ends

Follow-up continues.

Symptoms and monitoring

Ask which medicines to continue, when to seek help and how response will be assessed.

Sources: nccp

Next decisions

The team reviews benefit, side effects and your priorities. Supportive and palliative care can help alongside active treatment. Ask for a clear next-step and contact plan.

Sources: nccp · hse

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 07

Blood tests between infusion visits

The infusion and test schedules are different.

Weekly blood counts

Irinotecan is given every 21 days, but the full blood count is required weekly, including the weeks without an infusion. Ask where the blood is taken, who checks the result and what to do if an appointment is missed.

Sources: nccp

Before the next cycle

Kidney and liver tests are required before each cycle. The team also reviews bowel symptoms, hydration, medicines and recovery before confirming more treatment.

Sources: nccp

Early versus delayed diarrhoea

Tell the nurse immediately about cramps, sweating or diarrhoea during or soon after infusion. Delayed diarrhoea starting after 24 hours uses a separate written rescue plan. Contact urgently if it persists, or if fever, severe pain, dehydration or reduced urine occurs.

Sources: nccp

Cunningham et al. 1998: irinotecan after fluorouracil failure

Studies can help explain why a treatment is offered. The schedule, previous medicines and tumour tests affect how well the evidence fits you.

In a historical trial after fluorouracil had stopped working, irinotecan helped people live longer and improved several cancer-related symptoms compared with supportive care alone. Treatment also caused side effects. The study does not compare irinotecan with every option used today.

Sources: trial

PREPARE FOR THE CONVERSATION

Questions worth asking

How is my treatment chosen?

Irinotecan alone is used for advanced bowel cancer after a fluorouracil-containing treatment has failed. Your team explains the aim, alternatives and how benefit will be reviewed.

Do I need to enter dates to understand the cycle?

No. The graph explains a general pattern. Your hospital arranges appointments; the guide and its safety information are available without entering anything.

Will I have a pump at home?

There is no home fluorouracil pump in this regimen. Your team chooses a cannula or central line based on your veins and wider treatment plan.

What happens if a dose is delayed?

The team checks the cause and may delay, reduce, change or stop one medicine. Ask which component changes and when you should next attend; do not restart yourself.

How will I know whether it is helping?

Scans, symptoms and clinical review assess benefit. A rash, side effect or good day alone cannot show whether the cancer is responding.

What about radiotherapy?

This NCCP regimen does not contain a routine radiotherapy course. If radiation is recommended separately, ask whether it is before, during or after these medicines.

What about fertility, pregnancy and breastfeeding?

Discuss fertility preservation and reproductive plans before treatment. Ask for the contraception and breastfeeding instructions for every medicine; the whole regimen may require longer precautions than one medicine alone.

Try explaining the plan back: Can you explain which visits are planned, whether a pump is involved, and which symptoms mean you should call today? No dates or symptom scores are needed to use this guide.

SOURCE TRANSPARENCY

Where this information comes from

Regimen schedule: NCCP 00213 v7. Medicine explanations and safety information: sources below. The timeline is an educational illustration, not a measured risk curve or an individual prediction.

- NCCP 00213 v7 · official regimen
- HSE: chemotherapy side effects and urgent advice
- Cunningham 1998 primary trial
- NCCP NCIS supportive antiemetic medicines V8 (2025)

SACTCheck · Developed by Dr Paul O'Brien · Sources checked 2026-11-04.
This information supports your treatment discussion. Your oncology team confirms your personal treatment and urgent-care plan.

Written source addresses

https://healthservice.hse.ie/documents/6553/00213_Irinotecan_Monotherapy.pdf

https://www2.hse.ie/conditions/chemotherapy/side-effects/

https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/9807987/

https://healthservice.hse.ie/documents/7180/Supportive_Care_Antiemetics_for_inclusion_NCIS_Medical_Oncology.pdf